that there was a sudden water shortage in the city after a dam broke but Hakim Abu'l Fath Gilani, who stayed on at Fatehpur Sikri, increasingly bemused and saddened by Akbar's absence, never mentioned any lack of water which he surely would have had that been the reason for the Padshah's absence.

Akbar had left Fatehpur Sikri to tend to his fractious border in the Punjab but on this journey he was also forced to deal with the consequences of two deaths that affected him deeply. The first was the death of his half-brother, Mirza Hakim. Late in 1585, Mirza Hakim 'after much madness… fell into pains difficult of treatment' and finally died of alcoholism. Immediately, the rebellious Kabuli noblemen showed signs of discontent, requiring Akbar's attention, for an old nightmare from the time of Babur himself had resurfaced— the Uzbeks. With Mirza Hakim, a convenient buffer, now dead, Abdullah Khan Uzbek* began to dream of empires in Afghanistan and Hindustan. But another death, in early 1586, was much more personally devastating for Akbar. Zain Khan Koka and Raja Birbal had been sent on an expedition against the troublesome Pashtun Yusufzais in the Swat and Bajaur regions but disagreement and mistrust between the two leaders led to Birbal falling into a trap that the Yusufzais laid for him in the crumbling defiles of Kabul's mountains. The Mughals suffered the worst defeat of Akbar's reign, in a massacre called the Yusufzai Disaster, in which more than 8,000 Mughal soldiers, including Birbal, were killed.

It is fitting that the sombre description of the death of this great poet-warrior of Akbar's court found a place in one of the most celebrated works of Brajbhasha of this period, Narottam's *Mancarit*, with its fluid mix of Perso-Arabic words and Persianized Braj a perfect reflection of Birbal's life itself:

> The emperor was seated in the royal court,
> The earth's Mlecchas and Khans stood around him, as did all the Raos and Rajas.
> Just then a petition from there (the Northwest) was brought to his attention.
> The shah called in his attendant, and asked
> what was the matter;
> 'Who died, and who was saved? Who has been wounded?'